

THE

UNDERSTUDY

SHE CARRIED THE SONG.
THEN SHE CARRIED THE POISON.

ELEVATED MUSIC-INDUSTRY THRILLER | FEATURE FILM

Written by Kelly R. Tenney

Logline

When gospel superstar Tamar Reese collapses onstage, her long-invisible assistant Deja Moore steps into the spotlight she has secretly craved.

Then Deja discovers she unknowingly delivered the poison. With a powerful manager framing her as the perfect suspect, she must choose between the career she was denied and the truth that could destroy them all.

A STAR-IS-BORN FANTASY BECOMES A MURDER TRAP

03

The Hook

A stolen voice. A poisoned icon. One live confession.

THE WOMAN WHO CARRIED THE MUSIC BECOMES THE WOMAN WHO CARRIED THE POISON

THE FANTASY

An invisible assistant inherits the stage she has wanted for years.

THE TRAP

Every piece of evidence points to her because she delivered the victim's daily shake.

THE EVENT

She turns a live gospel awards performance into testimony before millions.



Tone & Comparables

Sacred spectacle meets institutional menace

ELEGANT	SUSPENSEFUL	MORALLY CHARGED
DREAMGIRLS	Ambition, authorship and the cost of standing behind the star	
THE ASSISTANT	Quiet coercion inside an institution built to protect power	
THE CLARK SISTERS	A lived-in gospel world with family, faith and performance at its center	
A FALL FROM GRACE	Accessible, female-led thriller stakes with a clear emotional engine	



05

DEJA MOORE

LATE 20s | THE INVISIBLE CREATOR

A gifted songwriter who spent four years making a gospel queen sound better while learning how thoroughly talent can disappear behind somebody else's name.

GOAL

Claim the career, credit and voice that Tamar took from her.

CONFLICT

Fame arrives through Tamar's collapse, binding Deja's dream to another woman's possible murder.

ARC

She moves from strategic silence to public testimony, accepting consequence as the price of authorship.

“I'M DONE BUYING QUIET.”

06

Marcus Vane

Manager. Architect. Predator.

He built Tamar's empire, monetized Deja's invisibility and treats every human relationship as an ownership agreement.

WEAPON

Narrative control. Marcus can turn a victim into a suspect before the crime has a name.

CONNECTION

He offers Deja the exact recognition she wants, then makes that recognition evidence of motive.

ARC

His empire collapses when Deja uses the one room he cannot privately own: a live national broadcast.

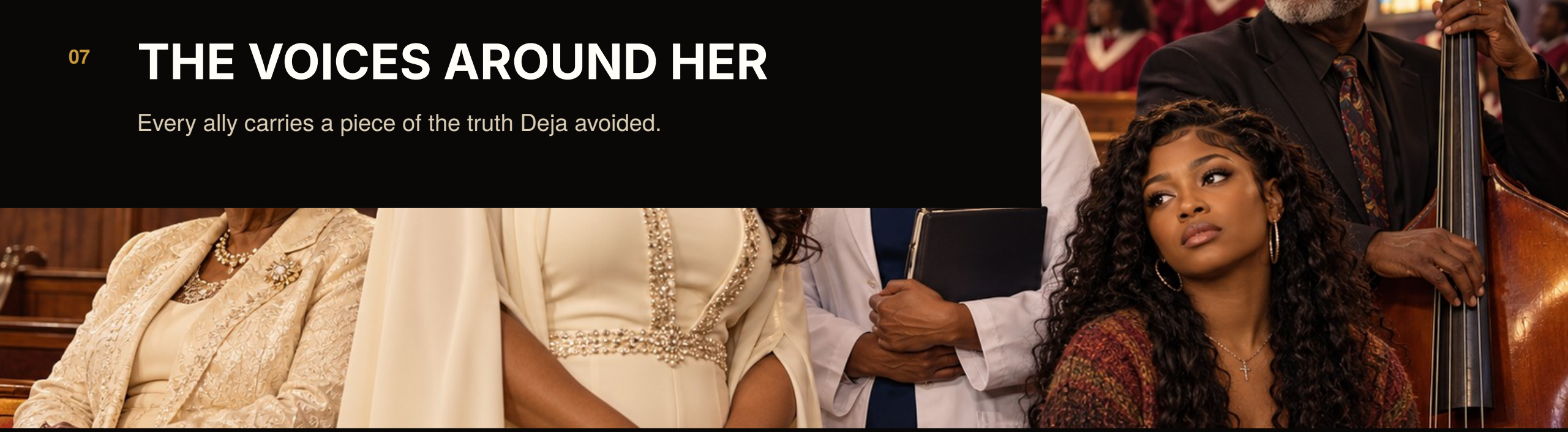
“I BUILT YOU A THRONE OR A CELL. SAME BLUEPRINT.”



07

THE VOICES AROUND HER

Every ally carries a piece of the truth Deja avoided.



TAMAR REESE

Gospel royalty whose stolen song and compromised memory bind Deja to the life she wanted.

DEACON WILLIS

Tamar's fired bandleader, carrying two decades of musical memory and one long-kept secret.

DR. ELOISE GRANT

The physician who recognizes poisoning, follows the evidence and refuses institutional pressure.

KENDRA

A gifted nineteen-year-old who shows Deja the next generation of talent entering the same machine.

MOTHER CLARA

Deja's spiritual anchor. She loves without flattering and insists that truth comes before mercy.

DET. RAY OKAFOR

A patient investigator who sees the frame around Deja before he sees the whole picture.

Story

A rise, a trap and a testimony

ACT I | THE VACUUM

Tamar collapses at the Fox Theatre. Deja's raw chapel performance goes viral, and Marcus promotes the assistant as the only voice capable of carrying the queen's music.

SPOTLIGHT

ACT II | THE DELIVERY SYSTEM

Deja finds messages about dosage and sedation. A doctor confirms thallium poisoning, while Marcus reveals that Deja's access, resentment and fingerprints make her the perfect fall woman.

EVIDENCE

ACT III | THE TESTIMONY

After saving Tamar from a second attack, Deja walks onto a live awards stage. She abandons the approved song, sings a confession and names the man who built her throne as a cell.

LIVE TRUTH

Visual Language

Sacred gold against poisonous green

THE LOOK

Atlanta at night
Ornate gospel spectacle
Red velvet and white satin
Hospital fluorescence
Rain on black pavement
Film grain and hard shadows

CAMERA

Close enough to feel the lie. Wide enough to reveal the machine around it.

BACKSTAGE BLACK

CATHEDRAL GOLD

QUEEN'S IVORY

VELVET OXBLOOD

POISON GREEN

CASTING WISHLIST

Prestige performers with musical credibility and moral weight



DEJA MOORE

Ryan Destiny

TAMAR REESE

Amber Riley

MARCUS VANE

Aldis Hodge

DR. ELOISE GRANT

Aunjanue Ellis-Taylor

DEACON WILLIS

Glynn Turman

MOTHER CLARA

Loretta Devine

Why It Fits BET+ / BET Studios

A familiar world with a fresh thriller engine

1. **Black women drive the story**
   Deja, Tamar, Dr. Grant and Mother Clara hold distinct power, guilt and agency.

2. **Gospel creates an event**
   The music, fashion and live-performance climax give the film strong promotional identity.

3. **The hook travels fast**
   A rising singer realizes she unknowingly delivered poison to the star she replaced.

4. **Production stays disciplined**
   Contained interiors anchor the film, while the Fox opening and awards finale provide scale.

5. **The conversation continues**
   Authorship, ambition, faith and exploitation invite debate after the thriller resolves.



Materials & Next Steps

Move from a strong screenplay to a package buyers can hear

AVAILABLE NOW

Revised 99-page screenplay
12-slide buyer pitch deck
Logline and story summary
Character and casting framework
Visual identity and platform positioning

PACKAGE NEXT

01 Complete final screenplay polish and proofread

02 Create a one-page sell sheet and full synopsis

03 Develop two original-song demos, including Deja's testimony hymn

04 Build a preliminary budget and music-rights strategy

05 Target director, music supervisor and lead attachments

THE TRUTH COSTS HER THE STAGE. IT GIVES HER BACK HER VOICE.